says agriculture minister S. Niranjan Reddy.

The state spent Rs 1.5 lakh crore on irrigation projects and Rs 28,473 crore to improve electricity infrastructure, apart from providing free 24x7 power to agricultural connections at a cost of Rs 10,500 crore. Crop yields are ahead of the national average in almost all major crops except groundnut and red gram.

Telangana is also the only state to invoke the Preventive Detection Act against suppliers of spurious seeds. In September, the state government and the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru, signed an agreement to jointly create India's first Agricultural Data Exchange. The state also launched the SaaguBaagu programme along with the World Economic Forum to promote new-age technologies like AI, IoT, remote sensing and block chain methods to solve problems unique to farmers.

Best Performing and Most Improved Small State: Puducherry

By 2015-16, Puducherry had more than halved its total cultivable area to 15,037 hectares from what it was in the 1970s but state interventions since then have helped reverse the trend and also increase crop productivity.

ABOUT 40 PER CENT OF PUDUCHERRY RESIDENTS ARE EITHER FARMERS OR INVOLVED IN ALLIED ACTIVITIES

With groundwater resources a concern, the government is focusing on new technologies like System for Rice Intensification and production incentives to grow less water-consuming crops such as pulses, oilseeds, millets and other horticultural crops. "We need an attitudinal change among farmers. They need to switch from paddy to less water-consuming crops such as high-yielding varieties of pulses and millets," says agriculture minister C. Djeacoumar. Growing pulses, millets, oilseeds and coconut is being encouraged.

The government has announced a novel scheme, En Veedu En Nalam, to promote vegetable cultivation in urban areas in a cluster approach. A market intervention mechanism, the Electronic National Agricultural Markets (e-NAM), was introduced in the principal regulated market at Thattanchavady in 2018 where all commodities are traded online on the national portal.

Puducherry has also forayed into digital agriculture with projects like the Intelligent Agricultural Advisory System, Remote Irrigation Management System and Agristack, the central IT farmers' database with linking of land records, geo-referencing of digitised village maps and real-time crop survey systems. The National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (Nabard) has assessed the potential linked credit plan (PLP) for Puducherry in FY2023-24 to be Rs 4,215 crore. ■

–Anilesh S. Mahajan and Amarnath K. Menon

MOST IMPROVED BIG STATES AGRICULTURE

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 320	RANK 2021
1	TELANGANA	275.0	2
2	RAJASTHAN	223.1	4
3	ASSAM	199.2	6
4	GUJARAT	199.0	10
5	MADHYA PRADESH	195.4	1
6	ANDHRA PRADESH	193.0	12
7	MAHARASHTRA	191.7	5
8	JHARKHAND	187.8	13
9	KARNATAKA	178.8	17
10	TAMIL NADU	166.9	14
11	UTTAR PRADESH	164.8	8
12	UTTARAKHAND	162.0	18
13	WEST BENGAL	151.0	11
14	CHHATTISGARH	139.8	9
15	ODISHA	137.4	16
16	BIHAR	134.8	7
17	HARYANA	126.2	3
18	KERALA	118.6	20
19	PUNJAB	99.4	15
20	HIMACHAL PRADESH	81.0	19

MOST IMPROVED SMALL STATES AGRICULTURE

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 320	RANK 2021
1	PUDUCHERRY	244.7	7
2	SIKKIM	196.1	2
3	MIZORAM	180.5	6
4	ARUNACHAL PRADESH	178.4	8
5	MANIPUR	170.1	1
6	NAGALAND	165.6	5
7	TRIPURA	143.4	3
8	MEGHALAYA	138.1	4
9	GOA	132.9	9

Note: Delhi was not considered under Agriculture category